

Consulting English Dialogue Lab

Realistic field-specific dialogues, role-play variations, and observer checklists

Audience: management consultants, strategy consultants, implementation consultants, analysts, engagement managers, client partners, internal consultants, and advisory teams

Focus: A consulting English curriculum for discovery, hypotheses, stakeholder management, scope, executive recommendations, slide narratives, implementation risk, and client pushback.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

Dialogue Practice Method

Read each exchange once for meaning, once for tone, and once for decision structure. Then complete the missing language by selecting one of four options and check the rationale at the end.

1. Client Discovery and Problem Definition

Setting

A client asks for a benchmark study but describes a decision problem.

Speaker	Line
Client partner	Sell the requested benchmark.
Client executive	Decision question, stakeholders, constraints, and expected use of analysis need clarification.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm discovery, problem statement, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Client partner	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short discovery question guide. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: discovery, problem statement.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects problem statement.

Option	Phrase
A	discovery
B	evidence threshold
C	approval path
D	operating constraint

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Sell the requested benchmark.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	I understand the urgency. I need to verify discovery and problem statement against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
B	I disagree, but I cannot name the boundary or the decision the group needs to make.
C	evidence threshold
D	approval path

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - A client asks for a benchmark study but describes a decision problem. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	Send every available detail to senior leaders without identifying the decision they need to make.
B	Wait for the problem to become visible before assigning an owner or evidence source.
C	evidence threshold
D	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the discovery question guide with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

2. Hypotheses and Issue Trees

Setting

The team has limited data but needs a workplan.

Speaker	Line
Engagement manager	Analyze everything.
Analyst	Hypotheses, issue tree, prioritization, and evidence plan should focus effort.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm hypothesis, issue tree, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Engagement manager	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short issue-tree workplan. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: hypothesis, issue tree.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects issue tree.

Option	Phrase
A	approval path
B	hypothesis
C	evidence plan

Option	Phrase
D	evidence threshold

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Analyze everything.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	approval path
B	operating constraint
C	decision owner
D	I understand the urgency. I need to verify hypothesis and issue tree against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - The team has limited data but needs a workplan. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the issue-tree workplan with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.
B	decision owner
C	Accept the request immediately because the stakeholder has already expressed urgency.
D	Send every available detail to senior leaders without identifying the decision they need to make.

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

3. Data Requests and Client Burden

Setting

The consulting team sends a long data request to a busy client.

Speaker	Line
Consultant	Ask for everything just in case.
Client data owner	Data relevance, owner, confidentiality, deadline, and burden need management.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm data request, confidentiality, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Consultant	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short data request prioritization. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: data request, confidentiality.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects confidentiality.

Option	Phrase
A	deadline
B	data request
C	confidentiality
D	owner

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Ask for everything just in case.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	approval path
B	I understand the urgency. I need to verify data request and confidentiality against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
C	I disagree, but I cannot name the boundary or the decision the group needs to make.
D	evidence threshold

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - The consulting team sends a long data request to a busy client. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	Send every available detail to senior leaders without identifying the decision they need to make.
B	Wait for the problem to become visible before assigning an owner or evidence source.
C	evidence threshold
D	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the data request prioritization with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

4. Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

Setting

A deck has many charts but no decision narrative.

Speaker	Line
Principal	Add more detail.
Consultant	So-what, implication, recommendation, and decision ask must be explicit.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm storyline, so what, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Principal	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short executive storyline. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: storyline, so what.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice**1. Complete the field language**

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects so what.

Option	Phrase
A	evidence threshold
B	approval path
C	operating constraint
D	storyline

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Add more detail.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	I understand the urgency. I need to verify storyline and so what against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
B	operating constraint
C	decision owner
D	We should act now and resolve storyline after the result is visible.

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - A deck has many charts but no decision narrative. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	Send every available detail to senior leaders without identifying the decision they need to make.
B	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the executive storyline with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.
C	decision owner
D	Accept the request immediately because the stakeholder has already expressed urgency.

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

5. Scope Management and Change Requests

Setting

A client asks for an additional market study mid-project.

Speaker	Line
Engagement manager	Do it to keep the client happy.
Client sponsor	Scope, timeline, budget, value, and tradeoff need a formal conversation.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm scope, change request, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Engagement manager	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short scope-change response. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: scope, change request.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects change request.

Option	Phrase
A	approval path
B	operating constraint
C	scope
D	evidence threshold

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Do it to keep the client happy.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	I disagree, but I cannot name the boundary or the decision the group needs to make.
B	evidence threshold
C	I understand the urgency. I need to verify scope and change request against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
D	A scope-change response is unnecessary; verbal assurance should be enough.

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - A client asks for an additional market study mid-project. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	Accept the request immediately because the stakeholder has already expressed urgency.
B	Send every available detail to senior leaders without identifying the decision they need to make.
C	Wait for the problem to become visible before assigning an owner or evidence source.
D	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the scope-change response with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

6. Difficult Client Feedback

Setting

A client says the recommendation is not practical.

Speaker	Line
Client executive	Defend the model.
Consultant	Implementation constraints, assumptions, and client knowledge should be integrated.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm assumption, implementation constraint, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Client executive	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short feedback recovery plan. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: assumption, implementation constraint.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects implementation constraint.

Option	Phrase
A	operating constraint
B	decision owner
C	implementation constraint
D	assumption

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Defend the model.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	evidence threshold
B	approval path
C	operating constraint
D	I understand the urgency. I need to verify assumption and implementation constraint against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - A client says the recommendation is not practical. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	approval path
B	operating constraint
C	decision owner
D	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the feedback recovery plan with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

7. Implementation and Change Management

Setting

Leadership approves a new operating model but managers resist.

Speaker	Line
Implementation lead	Tell managers the decision is final.

Speaker	Line
Business unit manager	Change story, incentives, decision rights, training, and adoption metrics matter.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm operating model, change management, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Implementation lead	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short implementation risk brief. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: operating model, change management.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects change management.

Option	Phrase
A	approval path
B	operating constraint
C	operating model
D	evidence threshold

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Tell managers the decision is final.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	A implementation risk brief is unnecessary; verbal assurance should be enough.
B	I understand the urgency. I need to verify operating model and change management against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
C	decision owner
D	We should act now and resolve operating model after the result is visible.

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - Leadership approves a new operating model but managers resist. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	approval path
B	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the implementation risk brief with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.
C	Wait for the problem to become visible before assigning an owner or evidence source.

Option	Phrase
D	evidence threshold

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

8. Steering Committees and Final Readouts

Setting

Executives disagree during the final readout.

Speaker	Line
Partner	Keep presenting the slides.
Executive sponsor	Decision rights, options, risks, and next-step ownership need facilitation.
ESL learner	I understand the goal, but we need to separate urgency from control. For this decision, I need to confirm steering committee, option set, the owner, and the evidence standard before we commit.
Partner	What would let us move forward without slowing everything down?
ESL learner	Let's document the assumption, define the risk trigger, and create a short steering committee close. Then we can decide whether to proceed, escalate, or revise the plan.

Language notes

- The learner names the field-specific control point instead of giving a vague no: steering committee, option set.
- The response preserves the business goal while adding evidence, owner, and next-step discipline.

Three-step decision practice

1. Complete the field language

Choose the term that belongs in this decision point.

Before we act, I need to confirm the _____ and how it affects option set.

Option	Phrase
A	risk
B	steering committee
C	decision owner
D	option set

2. Choose the strongest professional response

Select the response that preserves the relationship while setting an evidence-based boundary.

A stakeholder says, 'Keep presenting the slides.' Which response gives a useful, professional form of pushback?

Option	Phrase
A	A steering committee close is unnecessary; verbal assurance should be enough.

Option	Phrase
B	I understand the urgency. I need to verify steering committee and option set against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.
C	decision owner
D	We should act now and resolve steering committee after the result is visible.

3. Select the next decision move

Choose the action that turns the discussion into a controlled workplace decision.

Given this situation - Executives disagree during the final readout. - what should happen next?

Option	Phrase
A	Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the steering committee close with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.
B	approval path
C	operating constraint
D	decision owner

Observer checklist

- Did the learner name the decision and the risk?
- Did the learner use at least two industry terms accurately?
- Did the learner give a concrete next step without overpromising?

Answer Key and Rationale

Check each stage after completing the practice sequence. The rationale explains the decision skill the strongest response demonstrates.

Client Discovery and Problem Definition - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. discovery	'discovery' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Client Discovery and Problem Definition - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. I understand the urgency. I need to verify discovery and problem statement against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Client Discovery and Problem Definition - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the discovery question guide with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Hypotheses and Issue Trees - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. hypothesis	'hypothesis' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Hypotheses and Issue Trees - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. I understand the urgency. I need to verify hypothesis and issue tree against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Hypotheses and Issue Trees - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the issue-tree workplan with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Data Requests and Client Burden - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. data request	'data request' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Data Requests and Client Burden - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. I understand the urgency. I need to verify data request and confidentiality against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Data Requests and Client Burden - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the data request prioritization with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. storyline	'storyline' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. I understand the urgency. I need to verify storyline and so what against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the executive storyline with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Scope Management and Change Requests - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. scope	'scope' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Scope Management and Change Requests - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. I understand the urgency. I need to verify scope and change request against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Scope Management and Change Requests - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the scope-change response with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Difficult Client Feedback - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. assumption	'assumption' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Difficult Client Feedback - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. I understand the urgency. I need to verify assumption and implementation constraint against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Difficult Client Feedback - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the feedback recovery plan with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Implementation and Change Management - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. operating model	'operating model' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Implementation and Change Management - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. I understand the urgency. I need to verify operating model and change management against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Implementation and Change Management - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the implementation risk brief with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.

Steering Committees and Final Readouts - 1. Complete the field language

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. steering committee	'steering committee' is the field-specific variable that must be checked before the team can proceed responsibly. This is the decision variable the learner must confirm before the team acts.

Steering Committees and Final Readouts - 2. Choose the strongest professional response

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. I understand the urgency. I need to verify steering committee and option set against the stated constraint before I recommend the next step.	The strongest response names the field terms, the constraint, and the condition for a recommendation without sounding defensive or passive. This response is specific, respectful, and appropriately conditional. It converts pressure into a controlled decision.

Steering Committees and Final Readouts - 3. Select the next decision move

Correct answer	Why it fits
A. Review the stated constraint with the accountable owner, then prepare the steering committee close with the evidence, tradeoff, and requested decision.	The best next move makes the evidence, tradeoff, owner, and requested decision visible in a concise workplace artifact. This sequence creates a concise, decision-ready artifact with a clear owner and evidence boundary.